



IFDC RESOURCE • NO. 4

IFDC TIPSHEET

REPORTING ON RAPE AND SEXUAL VIOLENCE

*Practical guidance for Sri Lankan journalists covering sexual violence involving
children and adults*

**A PUBLICATION OF THE INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD
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REPORTING ON RAPE AND SEXUAL VIOLENCE

Practical guidance for Sri Lankan journalists covering sexual violence involving children and adults

Sexual violence is among the most difficult subjects a journalist will ever cover. It carries deep stigma in Sri Lankan society, and how a story is handled can genuinely affect whether a survivor heals or is harmed further. This tipsheet distils practical guidance for reporters and editors covering rape and sexual violence involving children and adults alike, with particular care where the survivor is a minor.

WHY IT MATTERS

Careless reporting has real consequences — survivors have taken their own lives, or faced violent retaliation from perpetrators or even relatives, after being identified in media coverage. Sri Lankan law reflects this risk directly: Section 365(C) of the Penal Code makes it a criminal offence, punishable by up to two years' imprisonment, to publish the name or identifying details of a sexual assault or rape victim.

1. Recognise the Survivor's Loss of Power

Survivors often describe feeling humiliated, unclean, or powerless after an assault. Many also live with real fear of retaliation from the attacker or from people connected to them. Reporting that reopens these feelings, or that increases a survivor's exposure to a perpetrator, compounds the original harm.

2. Take Extra Care in Conflict and Displacement Settings

Sexual violence is frequently used as a weapon during armed conflict and its aftermath. Reporters working with survivors from conflict-affected communities in Sri Lanka's Northern and Eastern Provinces should approach interviews with particular caution, listening more than asking, and never pressing for detail the survivor has not offered.

3. Keep Interviews Small and Controlled

- Limit the number of people present — a large crew or entourage can feel intimidating or exposing.
- Avoid bringing translators, photographers or other staff into the room unless genuinely necessary.
- Never allow children to be present during an interview about sexual violence, even as bystanders.

4. Think About Who Conducts the Interview

Many survivors of sexual violence find it easier to speak with a woman. Gauge the survivor's comfort, and where possible offer the option of a female interviewer or colleague.

5. Understand the Weight of Shame

Shame and humiliation are often the survivor's dominant emotions, and in some communities the social consequences of being identified can be severe — including rejection by family, loss of marriage prospects, or ostracism. Consider whether masking a survivor's identity, even beyond the legal minimum, better serves their long-term safety.

6. Never Pressure a Survivor to Talk

- Do not offer payment, favours or any other inducement to secure an interview.

- Never publish a survivor's name without their clear, informed and voluntary consent — and remember that in Sri Lanka doing so may also be a criminal offence under Section 365(C) of the Penal Code.
- Where a request to publish identifying detail comes from police investigating the case, confirm it in writing and route it through your editor before acting on it.

7. Protect Identity Even When Filming

- Use backlighting, shadow, or blurring techniques to obscure a survivor's identity on camera.
- Remember that digital enhancement tools can undo standard obscuring techniques — err on the side of stronger protection, not the minimum needed to pass review.

8. Handle Blame and Graphic Detail With Extreme Care

- Never frame language in a way that implies the survivor invited or was responsible for the assault.
- Include graphic detail only where it serves the story and the public's understanding — weigh this against the potential harm to the survivor every time.

9. Respect Local and Cultural Norms

Sri Lanka is culturally diverse, and norms around touch, eye contact, gender interaction and language differ across communities. Learn and respect these before an interview, and choose a private, low-stigma setting rather than a public or visible one.

10. Signpost Help — Every Time

A story about sexual violence can surface painful memories for readers or viewers who are survivors themselves. Include information on where to get help in every published piece.

SRI LANKA SUPPORT RESOURCES

National Child Protection Authority (NCPA) Childline: 1929 (toll-free, 24-hour, trilingual). Women and Children's helpline: 119. Sri Lanka Police can also be contacted directly for cases requiring urgent intervention. Journalists should keep these numbers on hand to include in coverage rather than leaving survivors and readers without a next step.

A Quick Checklist Before Publishing

1. Have I obtained informed, voluntary consent for anything that could identify the survivor?
2. Does this story name or imply the survivor's identity in a way that breaches Section 365(C) of the Penal Code?
3. Have I avoided any language that could be read as assigning blame to the survivor?
4. Have I included a local helpline or support resource?
5. If a child is involved in any way, have I kept them out of the interview setting entirely?

Adapted with gratitude from the guidance of Mark Brayne, editor of "Trauma & Journalism: A Guide for Journalists, Editors & Managers" (Dart Centre for Journalism & Trauma, 2007), with Sri Lankan legal and support-service context added by the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC). Reference: Brayne, M. (Ed.). (2007). Trauma & Journalism: A Guide for Journalists, Editors & Managers. Dart Centre for Journalism & Trauma. © IFDC — www.ifdchild.org.

GET HELP · REPORT A CONCERN · KNOW YOUR RESOURCES

Sri Lankan Bodies Every Journalist Covering Children Should Know

EDITORS' GUILD OF SRI LANKA

No. 96, Kirula Road, Colombo 05, Sri Lanka

Self-regulatory body for editors — Code of Professional Practice

PRESS COMPLAINTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (PCCSL)

96 Bernard Soysa Mawatha (Kirula Road), Colombo 00500

Web: www.pccsl.lk

Independent Dispute Resolution Council for complaints against the press

HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (HRCSL)

No. 14, R. A. De Mel Mawatha, Colombo 04

Tel: 011 250 5580 / 011 250 5581 / 011 250 5582 · Hotline: 1996

Web: www.hrcsl.lk

LEGAL AID COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA

No. 129, Hulftsdorp Street, Colombo 12

Tel: +94 11 243 3618 / +94 11 533 5329 / +94 11 533 5281

Email: legalaids@sltnet.lk · Web: www.legalaids.gov.lk

Free legal advice and court representation for eligible persons, including in child-related matters

NATIONAL CHILD PROTECTION AUTHORITY (NCPA)

No. 330, Thalawathugoda Road, Madiwela, Sri Lanka

Childline: 1929 (toll-free, 24 hours, trilingual) · Tel: +94 11 277 8911–14

Email: ncpa@childprotection.gov.lk · Web: www.childprotection.gov.lk

INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD (IFDC)

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